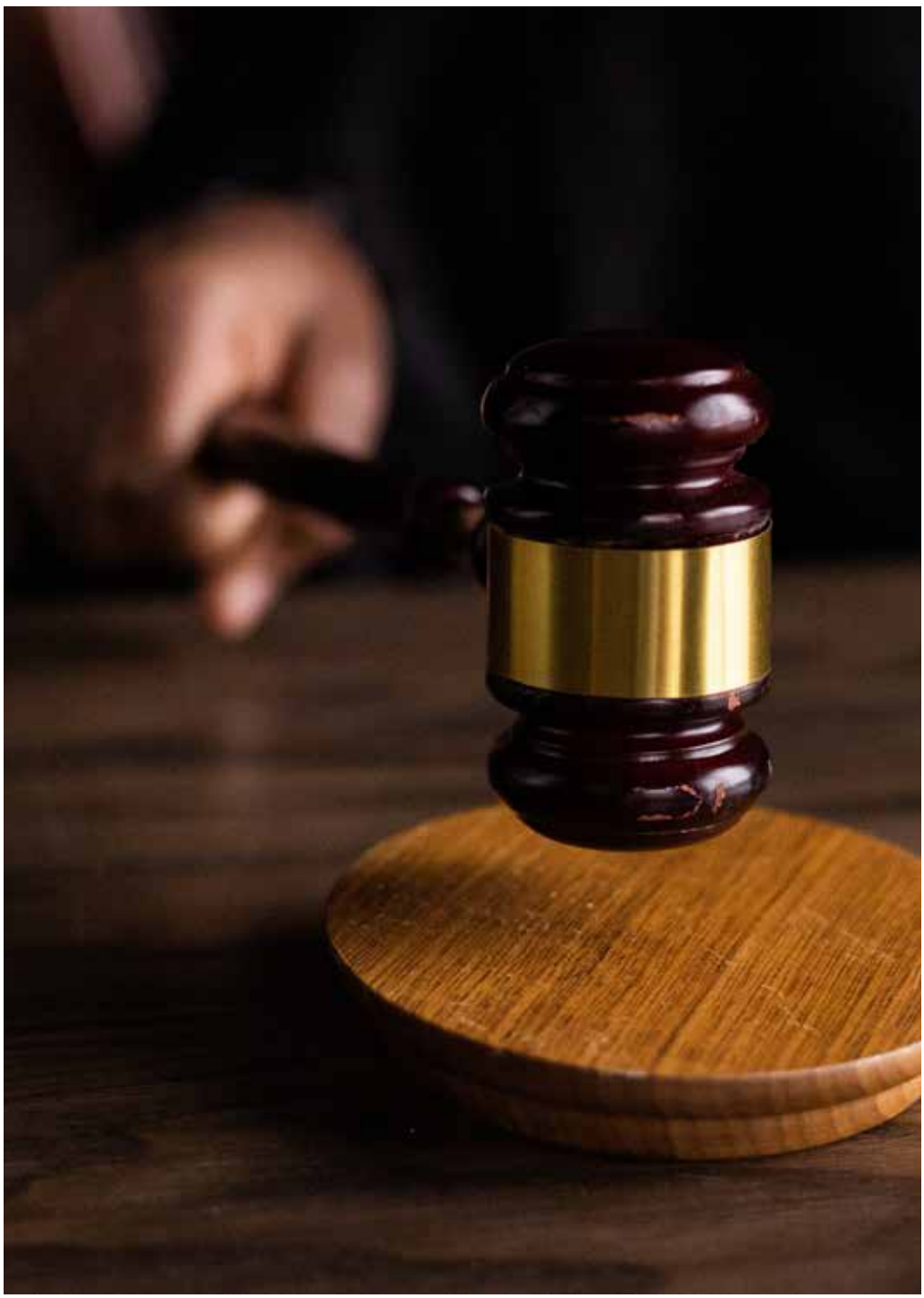
FROM ROBOTS TO MOVIE STARS: HOW AI IS TRANSFORMING CAREERS

How AI has impacted professionals around the world

By Capri Wayne



While in London this June, I decided to visit Bletchley Park, where British codebreakers broke the German Enigma code during World War II, saving an estimated 14 million lives. Alan Turing, the inventor of the codebreaking bombe machine, was one of the founding fathers of artificial intelligence, developing the eponymous Turing Test which determines if a machine can imitate human conversation.

The lady at the Waterloo Underground ticket office had never heard of Bletchley.

After managing to secure a ticket, I arrived and eventually saw the largely-forgotten bombe machine—with those once-magical wheels and plugboard, the first computer to perform a job too complicated for the human brain to tackle.

Although the bombe was discontinued, the research and advancement never stopped. In the 1980s, computer scientist and "Godfather of AI" Geoffrey Hinton made breakthroughs in deep learning, developing models and algorithms inspired by the human brain. Deep learning is the basis of much of the AI that is changing our lives today—especially our careers. For most people, the debate around AI is largely centered on the cost of human jobs. As this transformative technology continues to improve, no profession will be left untouched.

For instance, the entertainment industry is currently facing a difficult period. Hollywood has faced over 20 strikes in its 100-year history. Usual demands include higher pay for actors and writers, especially in the form of residuals. However, strikers in 2023 are demanding something new: protection against artificial intelligence.



The Writers Guild of America has been on strike since May 2023, with SAG-AFTRA (Screen Actors Guild) following shortly in July. "AI can scan an actor and use their 'likeness' without compensating that actor for eternity," SAG-AFTRA member and actress Amy Dorris said. "[Background actors] would get paid for 1 day of work then AI would change their clothes, expressions, and do the acting for them. This would create job loss."

Although background actors face the bulk of the dangers, famous actors are not immune. With AI using their likeness, celebrities can be exploited or made to do things they would never have done in reality. Even dead actors can be resurrected with AI—an example being James Dean, whose digital clone will be starring in an upcoming film 70 years after his death.

For Dorris, who has been a SAG-AFTRA member since 1999, the entertainment industry has changed drastically in the last decade. "Hollywood execs are making 20 million dollars a year while famous actors doing streaming shows can't pay their bills," Dorris said. "I've heard of [streaming] residuals as low as $0.02. It is not sustainable to be a working actor anymore."

Dorris hopes for fair solutions to the issue of using AI-generated actors. "I think [AI] is great for special effects," Dorris said. "There needs to be consent and fair compensation if AI will be used for the likeness of an actor."

Meanwhile, in China, many hotels and restaurants now have robots to serve, clean, and carry out other housekeeping tasks. How have they become so commonplace? One reason is SoftBank Robotics Group.

Christine Qing works for SoftBank Robotics Group, a company that commercializes robots and brings them into the market. SoftBank robots feature a range of functions: customer service (Pepper), food service (X1), floor scrubbing (Scrubber 50 Pro), and vacuuming (Whiz).

"What we're trying to do with [robots] is automate," Qing said. "Automate the repetitive tasks, or sometimes dangerous tasks."

AI plays a large part in this process. For example, machine learning is used to train robots, teaching them spatial awareness and how to perform certain tasks. Qing feels that AI is a helpful and necessary tool. "I think that AI is something inevitable [that] is going to happen, and it's happening right now," Qing said. "We have to work with that. We have to set up the right framework to make sure we are using it right."

She believes in the importance of adapting to AI and uses it in her day-to-day work. "Our



company has encouraged us to use ChatGPT," Qing said. "You have to know how to use [AI programs]."

As technology continues to improve, SoftBank is working on even more special robots to automate life on a daily basis. "There will be warehouse automation and there will be delivery automation," Qing said.

Additionally, finance is another sector being transformed by AI. In the fast-paced world of finance, innovation is key. Ken Li, a quantitative analyst at a proprietary trading shop, uses ChatGPT to assist in his day-to-day job, but not in an official capacity.

"I sometimes just use the chatbot to give myself new ideas," Li said. "Doing research means you have to come up with your own questions and hypotheses—but I don't know what I don't know. If I ask the chatbot how one should approach a topic, occasionally new ideas could pop up."

At present, Li considers AI to be more helpful than it is dangerous. He has long been impressed by AI tools like Photoshop's generative fill and GitHub Copilot. However, he still recognizes the technology's limitations. "In finance, we often quote the phrase 'garbage in, garbage out'," Li said. "When you feed [financial data] to a generic model without deep analysis or transformations, you can't expect something amazing to come out of it."

AI has already permeated the finance sector, with Bloomberg launching its own AI language model, BloombergGPT, built specifically for finance. Today, chatbots handle many customer inquiries and offer financial advice. As more financial institutions turn to AI algorithms and robotics, the landscape of the industry is and will be profoundly impacted.

For Fox Gu, who will soon be studying law at Northwestern University, AI is an often-discussed topic. Gu graduated from New York University with a degree in philosophy, an area that often intersects with the ethics of AI. "My professor, David Chalmers, attends the International Morality Conference in Amsterdam every year," Gu said. "They're not only discussing [how] AI can morally affect us; they're more about 'how do we morally judge AI?'"

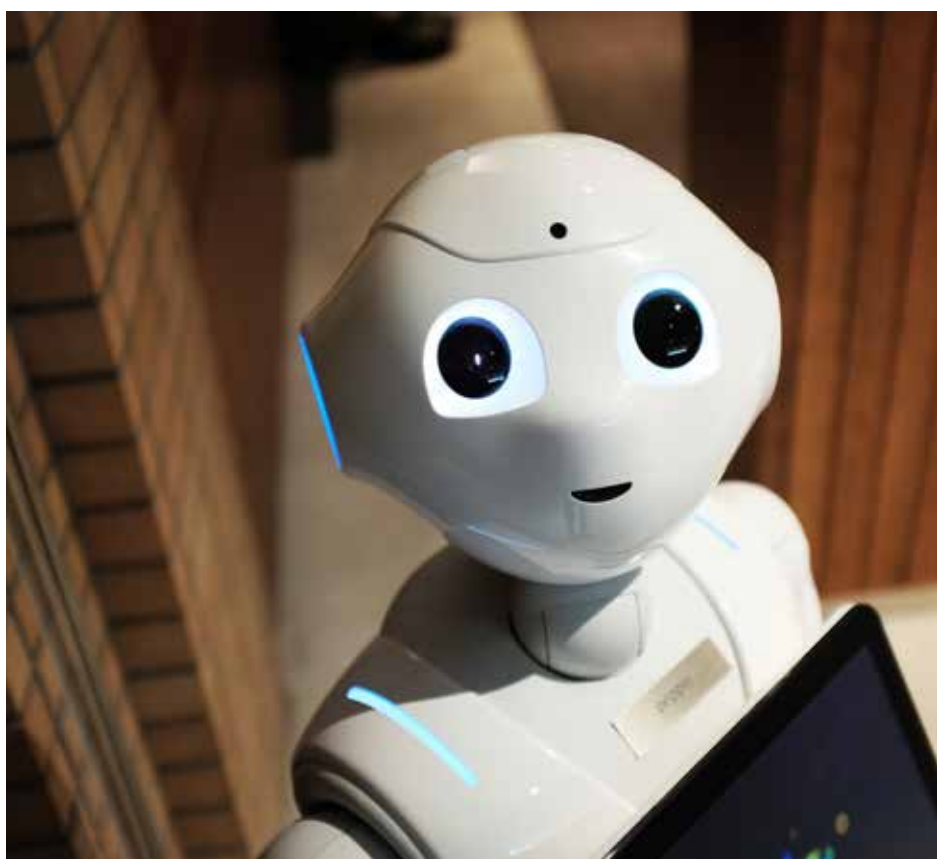
For many future lawyers, AI will certainly be a phenomenon they come across. "There's never going to be an area that is called artificial intelligence law," Gu said. "The law will only be what artificial intelligence can affect. There will be new laws regarding AI in a business setting, in an important employment setting, in intellectual property."

Like Qing, Gu believes that ChatGPT and other AI tools will become a necessary skill for those seeking employment in the future. "We much prefer people who know how to use ChatGPT efficiently because ChatGPT will basically become like Microsoft Word or PowerPoint," Gu said. "In the future, companies will rely on these tools more."

He acknowledges the loss of jobs but suggests the creation of new careers. "Every technology in the end will kill some jobs, like some jobs will become obsolete," Gu said. "But in general, with every advancement of new technology, a lot of new jobs and companies surround this new technology."

"In the end, [a lawyer's] role is to help solve real-world issues, what happens day to day, and artificial intelligence is not a thing that happens," Gu said. "It is a phenomenon."

From Hollywood's ongoing strikes over AI-generated actors to SoftBank's AI-integrated robots, and from AI's influence on finance to its intersection with the legal field, the presence of AI is reshaping the way we work and interact with technology. While concerns about job loss persist, it's important to recognize the importance of adaptation and the new opportunities that AI will bring. Through embracing AI and its strategic implementation, we shall hopefully find ourselves in a world where AI enhances our capabilities and allows for further progress.



PHOTOS: PEXELS